

Cover to *Iron Man: Extremis* (2010 hardcover edition) by Adi Granov.

"We talked a lot about the cave in *Iron Man 1*," Broussard explains. "Tony was stripped of everything and thrown in a cave, and he came out a super hero. We wanted this entire movie to have that feeling of the cave."

Kevin Feige, Producer of *Iron Man 3* and President of Marvel Studios, agrees. "*Iron Man 3* is very much inspired by the first half of *Iron Man 1*," he says. "We've always said let's get Tony back to the cave, where he's backed up against a wall and he's gotta use his intelligence to get out of it. He can't call Thor, he can't call Cap, he can't call Nick Fury, and he can't look for the Helicarrier in the sky."

Faced with the challenge of topping *Marvel's The Avengers*, the studio braintrust decided to go against expectations and, instead, *narrow* the new film's focus. "We're not aiming for bigger, necessarily," Feige says. "We're aiming for different and fresh and new."

Broussard elaborates: "We made the decision that, post-*Avengers*, wherever possible, these movies were going to go back into their own worlds. Tony is interesting on his own. We haven't seen Rhodey lately; we haven't seen that much of Pepper Potts or Stark Industries. These things that are central to Tony's world—let's have fun exploring those, because they're so rich and there's so much there in the comics.

"Once we made that decision, to just go back and focus on Tony's world, it freed us up in a way that was exciting. It allowed us to not be beholden to a lot of the other, larger, Marvel Cinematic Universe continuity."

Louis D'Esposito, Executive Producer and Co-President of Marvel Studios, adds: "What's great about our Marvel characters is that they're interesting without their super-powers. People can relate to Tony Stark. You feel he's a real person—the same as Captain America and Thor, with Thor being a son, and having father issues and brother issues. Our heroes are successful because of that relatability. They have these issues and obstacles that they have to overcome besides playing out on the world stage."

Key to this approach was the vision of new director Shane Black. Black had built an impressive reputation by writing the *Lethal Weapon* movies, and he had consulted informally on the first two *Iron Man* films. His directorial debut, *Kiss Kiss Bang Bang*, starred a face familiar to Marvel movie fans: Robert Downey Jr.

"You hire a director ultimately to imprint their personality on a story," D'Esposito says, "and you look at Shane Black and what he's accomplished over the years. You know you're gonna get an interesting tone, an interesting take on the film."